

Political Theory, Final Review

Personal study notes for the PSC 400 final, December 2025

Justice and the city, Plato

The just city mirrors the just soul. Three parts, reason, spirit, appetite. Justice is each part doing its own work. Watch for the analogy and its limits.

Authority and consent

Hobbes, fear of the state of nature drives the covenant, the sovereign holds order. Locke, consent is conditional, government protects life, liberty, and property, and may be replaced. Compare the exit conditions.

Liberty, Mill

Harm principle, the only ground for coercion is preventing harm to others. Tension with paternalism and with the tyranny of the majority. Be ready to apply it to a current case.

Justice as fairness, Rawls

Original position and the veil of ignorance. Two principles, equal basic liberties, then the difference principle. Know why the parties would not gamble on utilitarianism.

Likely essay questions

One, compare Locke and Rawls on the basis of legitimate authority. Two, apply Mill to a campus speech case. Plan both answers before the exam, do not draft cold.